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Original Research Article

Maintaining Active Lifestyle Through Pickleball: A Qualitative Exploration of Older Pickleball Players

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Abstract

This study aimed to explore the experiences of older adults engaged in pickleball. In particular, we collected views from the USA Pickleball Association (USAPA) ambassadors to identify how their experiences facilitate successful aging. A qualitative case study was utilized to obtain naturalistic data. Purposive sampling was used to recruit a total of 15 USAPA ambassadors, all of whom were interviewed in person. Data were analyzed using interpretive thematic analysis, and four overarching themes were generated: (a) a new way to stay active, (b) pickleball is social, (c) an intergenerational pastime, and (d) reestablishing an identity through pickleball. The findings support the view that engaging in pickleball is a promising means of achieving a healthy life as a senior citizen. The participants maintained a physically and mentally active lifestyle through pickleball, and their commitment to this sport led to their engagement as ambassadors in their communities.

Keywords

older adults, physical activity, pickleball, leisure, successful aging

Pickleball is one of the fastest-growing sports in the United States. It is often described as a combination of tennis, badminton, and table tennis. Pickleball is a racket sport that is played on a badminton-sized court using a special paddle and a wiffleball. Pickleball

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is most commonly played in the form of doubles games, but singles games are also played. Pickleball was invented in 1965. However, it only attained popularity in the 2000s when pickleball was introduced at the National Senior Games in 2008. Numerous senior communities in the United States subsequently adopted the sport into their programs. Senior Games are multisport events for adults aged 50 years and older. Track and field events attracted the most participants to the Senior Games in the past but recently, pickleball has now overtaken athletics events in popularity. Pickleball is now one of the most popular and important events in most Senior Games in the United States.

The USA Pickleball Association (USAPA) is the national governing body for pickleball in the United States. The USAPA (2022) claims the existence of more than four million pickleball players in the United States. Both pickleball players and the places they can play have increased significantly in number. Pickleball is also played worldwide: the International Federation of Pickleball has over 60 member countries. This sport appeals particularly to older adults because it has a short initial learning curve. Most pickleball competitions group players according to age and skill level. A rating system is used to designate the skill levels of pickleball players, with 1.0 denoting a novice and 5.0 signifying the most advanced level for a player. Most pickleball competitions are open to players of varying skill levels. A recent study on pickleball players demonstrated the diversification of the skill ratings of tournament participants (Kim et al., 2021).

The existing research has shown that older adults engaged in pickleball experience individual and social benefits (Buzzelli & Draper, 2020; Ryu et al., 2018). For example, Wray et al. (2021) conducted a 6-week intervention study with adults aged between 50 and 75 years and examined discrete health outcomes. They noted increased cognitive performance, enhanced vertical jump height, and reduced perceived pain as the notable outcomes of the pickleball intervention. Ryu et al. (2022) studied pickleball players who participated in Senior Games, testing associations between several psychosocial constructs. As reported by previous studies (e.g., Heo et al., 2018), playing pickleball was regarded as a serious leisure activity and a key predictor of eudaimonic well-being. Other personality characteristics such as conscientiousness, neuroticism, and openness to experience were also related to eudaimonic well-being. In addition to the benefits of pickleball experiences, literature shows various types of leisure activities also have positive impacts on the well-being of older adults. For instance, Morris et al. (2023) demonstrated the feasibility of delivering an online dancing program (i.e., ParkinDANCE Online) to people living with Parkinson's disease (PD). Tamplin et al. (2020) conducted a 12-month controlled clinical trial study and found that engaging in therapeutic group singing (i.e., ParkinSong) significantly contributes to the well-being of both people with PD and their caregivers.

According to Stebbins (2020), serious leisure is characterized by deep engagement, commitment, and high levels of involvement in a pastime. When individuals pursue serious leisure, it requires devotion which comes with the acquisition and expression

of special skills as well as knowledge. Research into serious leisure has continued to evolve, and recent scholarly explorations of serious leisure have included a variety of activities such as bridge (Punch et al., 2022), bird watching (Lee et al., 2021), board games, swimming (Kim et al., 2022), running (Zhou et al., 2021), yoga (Liu et al., 2022), trekking, dancing (Heikkinen, 2021), and volunteering (Hallmann et al., 2023). Another study of pickleball players examined the links between pickleball participation, social capital, and happiness (Kim et al., 2021). The participants of that study comprised older pickleball players who competed at a national tournament, and pickleball was considered a form of serious leisure. Specifically, Kim et al.'s study investigated the mediating role of social capital in the association between pickleball participation and happiness. Neighborhood connections and feelings of trust and safety mediated the associations between participation in pickleball and happiness in older adults.

The USAPA estimates that more than 2,200 people have been appointed as USAPA ambassadors (hereafter, ambassadors). The USAPA has instituted an ambassador program to promote pickleball in discrete regions. According to the USAPA (2022), ambassadors are "volunteer representatives and unofficial spokespersons." Older adults serving as ambassadors could represent exemplary cases involving serious leisure activities undertaken by older adults. Stebbins (2007) theorized that volunteering is a form of serious leisure, and the principal responsibilities of ambassadors as community volunteers are to promote and develop the sport of pickleball. Older adults are likely to attain numerous personal and social benefits such as self-fulfillment, feelings of accomplishment self-esteem, social interaction, and belongingness when volunteering becomes central to their daily lives as a serious leisure activity (Brown et al., 2008; Cheng et al., 2016; Joseph & Southcott, 2019; Lee et al., 2019; Schneider & McCoy, 2018; Zhou et al., 2022).

The existing literature elucidates that pickleball is a promising sports activity for older adults. Previous studies have highlighted that engaging in the pickleball community amounts to participation in a serious leisure activity, which offers senior citizens new insights into successful aging (e.g., Ryu et al., 2022). The pickleball ambassadors spearhead the growth of the sport and constitute the core of its development. The existing literature supports the claim that the ambassadors form the focal group of committed participants. The present study purposed to explore the experiences of older adults engaged in pickleball. Specifically, we collected the opinions of the ambassadors to identify how their experiences contributed to successful aging. This aspect has not yet been explored, particularly in a qualitative approach; hence, the findings of our study will contribute to a better understanding of knowledge sources relevant to the importance of engaging in pickleball in later life. In other words, the present study utilized a semi-structured interview in order to explore how experiences of pickleball influence older adults' life. The following specific research questions were posed: (a) How do ambassadors consider their role within communities? and (2) How do older adults believe their pickleball experiences lead to a healthy life?

Method

We utilized a qualitative case study to obtain naturalistic data (Yin, 2009). This approach is useful for investigations of contemporary phenomena in real-life situations. We aimed to attain a deeper understanding of a complex social phenomenon in pickleball communities. We deemed semistructured interviews appropriate for our research purposes because they offered the respondents opportunities to illustrate their pickleball-related experiences. The interviews entailed discussions on topics such as the experience of playing pickleball, the challenges and benefits of serving as an ambassador, efforts undertaken to promote pickleball, and the group culture of ambassadors.

Participants

We utilized purposive sampling to recruit ambassadors as participants for the present study. We obtained the contact information of the ambassadors from the USAPA website. We contacted a total of 15 ambassadors via email, and all of them agreed to participate in the study. None of the ambassadors who received the email refused to participate. Our eligibility criteria for the study's participants specified individuals who (a) had played pickleball for at least a year, (b) were 50 years or older, (c) were officially appointed by the USAPA as local ambassadors, and (d) could recall and explain their experiences as ambassadors. We interviewed five females and 10 males. The participants' ages ranged between 51 and 77 years (average age = 66.6 years). Three participants were employed full-time, one participant worked part-time, and 11 participants were retired. A total of 13 participants identified as Caucasian, and two as African American. Most participants had attended post-secondary institutions. All but one participant was married. The skill levels of the participants ranged between intermediate and advanced. Their duration of playing pickleball varied, ranging between one and 18 years (average = 7.13 years). Table 1 presents the demographic characteristics of the participants.

Data Collection

We interviewed all participants face-to-face. The participants selected the interview location based on their comfort and convenience, for instance, their office, a sports facility, or a coffee shop. The interviews lasted between 45 and 60 min and were recorded and transcribed verbatim. Field notes were also taken during the interviews. The authors conducted all the interviews in a southern state in the United States. The interviews began with a broad question: "Could you tell us about your experience of pickleball?" Subsequently, the participants were asked to discuss in more detail their experiences of playing pickleball and being an ambassador. We asked questions such as, "What do you think is most important in your work as an ambassador?" "Does the ambassador experience mean anything to you?" "What difficulties do you face as an ambassador?" and "Is being an ambassador important to you?"

Table 1. Demographic Characteristics of the Participants.

Pseudonym	Age	Gender	Ethnicity	Marital status	Education level	Employment	Years played pickleball
Ben	69	Male	Caucasian	Married	Some college	Retired	5
Clara	51	Female	Caucasian	Married	College	Employed	9
Jordan	75	Male	Caucasian	Married	College	Retired	1
Carl	70	Male	Caucasian	Married	College	Retired	11
Esther	71	Female	Caucasian	Married	College	Retired	10
Pam	74	Female	Caucasian	Married	High school	Employed	3
Miles	72	Male	Caucasian	Married	Masters	Retired	7
Tom	51	Male	Caucasian	Single	Masters	Employed	2
David	62	Male	Caucasian	Married	Some college	Retired	3
Frank	66	Male	Caucasian	Married	Masters	Retired	4
Tony	51	Male	Caucasian	Married	Some college	Employed	4
Kate	77	Female	Caucasian	Married	Some college	Retired	13
Dan	69	Male	Caucasian	Married	College	Retired	15
Jane	73	Female	African American	Married	Masters	Retired	18
Carol	68	Female	African American	Married	Some college	Retired	2

Data Analysis

We analyzed the data using an interpretive thematic analysis, engaging in regular discussions during the analysis process to reduce researcher bias. We read the transcripts and developed the codes inductively. We organized codes into categories as coding structures were developed (Yin, 2016). After refining and reducing the categories, we developed a final list of overarching themes under which the codes were grouped.

Trustworthiness of the Study

Both authors have spent sufficient time within the pickleball field, which has facilitated an understanding of the culture and context of the study's theme. We have both been involved in pickleball and have been competing in pickleball tournaments for multiple years. Further, we have organized and operated pickleball tournaments for several

years. Hence, we can attest to our long-term engagement with the topic of our study. Our appropriate experience in the pickleball community allowed us to easily establish rapport with the participants at the outset. By the time the interviews were conducted, the lead author had been working as an ambassador in the same state as the participants. The first author's involvement with the USAPA assisted in the development of affinity before the interviews and helped during data collection. We also performed member checks by sending the transcripts to the participants to ensure the accuracy of the data.

Results

The participants shared their experiences and stories about their active involvement in the pickleball community and discussed the significant role enacted by pickleball in later life. Our data analysis generated four overarching themes: (a) a new way to stay active, (b) pickleball is social, (c) an intergenerational pastime, and (d) reestablishing an identity through pickleball.

A New Way to Stay Active

All the participants valued pickleball very highly as a means of remaining physically and mentally active. Research has demonstrated the physical and cognitive health benefits (e.g., Wray et al., 2021) of this pastime, and these benefits were reiterated by the participants. Miles saw evident improvement in the physical health of the members from playing pickleball. According to Miles,

> We've had several of those kinds of people who had high cholesterol who started playing and their cholesterol has gone down, high blood pressure has gone down, some of them have lost weight, you know they just generally feel better about themselves, so it has that sort of health benefit as well for some people.

The participants acknowledged other health benefits apart from the reduction of health risks: for instance, agility, balance, coordination, and flexibility. In Esther's words, "I find that I have picked up my eye hand coordination. I'm quicker at the net, you have to be because the ball is coming back fast and I've just got a lot better at that." Smith et al.'s (2018) research on the physiological responses of middle-aged and older pickleball players suggested that pickleball could be classified as moderate-intensity exercise. Pickleball can also serve as a vigorous intensity workout depending on how it is played. Clara elucidated that pickleball keeps her active and alive:

> This gives you exercise plus energy. You know you're doing something, you're engaged in it. I like that better from an activity perspective, than just being in the gym and working out repetitively. I think it is great for any age group because it gets us off the couch and out of the screen.

The participants talked about their purposeful efforts to play pickleball, and their narratives consistently revealed significant personal health benefits. Carl shared a similar opinion about the mental health benefits he attained as he described his experience of playing in pickleball competitions:

> The game is real mental and by that, I mean, when you're playing in a competition, for example, I don't want my opponents to ever see me worried. It's a mental game. I don't want to let them psych me out. When you hit a bad ball, some people get really upset about that, and I'm mad at myself for about 1.9 seconds, and then I forget it happened. I think the games are, if you want to play at a higher level, you got to play mentally as well as physically fit.

Setting goals helps people maintain meaningful lifestyles during retirement (Dudley et al., 2020). Goalsetting could help individuals attain a life purpose, and pickleball seems to offer participants directions toward their next targets. In Carl's view,

> I'm trying to get better at my pickleball, so I'll come over and I'll do drills. I have a ball machine and I'll hit 300 drop shots in an hour, maybe 100, 200 volleys just by myself practicing those shots. I go to the gym three days a week. I spent half an hour in the gym this morning on the rower, came over and played pickleball went home, had lunch, watched TV and came back over here to play a little bit more.

Carl's statements clarified that some participants demonstrated specific achievement goals vis-à-vis pickleball. In his mid-60s, Frank appeared a very competitive player among our respondents. Frank mentioned during his interview that he used to play tennis at a very competitive level and that he transitioned to pickleball as he got older. He has competed in numerous local and national pickleball events as well as in the Senior Games. Frank disclosed his goals and plans for pickleball. He said, "I've been to many tournaments yeah 87 medals and counting. Hopefully 88 (medals) the day after tomorrow. My goal is to win a hundred medals in three years or less."

Pickleball Is Social

Pickleball is known to be a social sport, and most pickleball communities welcome beginners or outsiders (Morris, 2022). The relationships built by the participants around pickleball appeared to extend to their other leisure domains. Participants opined that pickleball had contributed to the development of lasting friendships. For instance, Dan asserted "You get a chance to meet people. Yes. and a lot of people here, on the weekends or whatever, they play cards together, they play golf together, they do social events for dinner together." Another participant, Jordan, claimed that he was always ready to help newcomers and emphasized that most members of the community were willing to take care of new entrants:

> Everybody is really congenial to each other. New people, we welcome new people. So what we do is we keep the one court to the left as you came in about 45 minutes for new people. If they want help, glad to help. Anybody will, not just me.

Kate, a 77-year-old retiree, also similarly said,

> If we know someone is coming in particular, we're going to have a guest, we'll say we're going to have a guest, and so people would encourage people to welcome them and make them feel welcomed and invite them back.

The participants consistently articulated the positive impact exerted by pickleball on their lives and reported how the sport has influenced their existence. Miles acknowledged the social nature of pickleball and emphasized friendly exchanges between the participants, saying, "everybody has fun, and they're talking to each other and it's much more social. I've seen a number of people almost change their lives based on the fact that they've started playing pickleball." Some participants mentioned the joys of traveling to compete in tournaments and commended the opportunities such tours offered players to strengthen their camaraderie and develop new friendships in their communities. During the interviews, David said, "We travel together. So we always root for one another. and we wear our shirts. So that way, whenever we go somewhere and you feel like you're at home, and you got friends." Clara stated that she often traveled out of town to compete in events and discussed the value of the friendships she developed over time:

> I think almost every tournament we go to, we have somebody's couch we can sleep on [laughs], almost every place that we go, but that says a lot, I mean you make these friendships and these relationships and they're like, 'Oh next time just stay with us.' You know, we've done that too, I mean we've stayed at people's houses or you know or we room with them or get a house or do something, so it's just, it's kind of one big family thing, it's kind of fun that way, so it's kind of cool that you know someone all over the country.

Pickleball has always been popular among older adults. Therefore, competitions and workshops catering specifically to older adults have proliferated nationwide. Some cruise ships have started offering onboard pickleball programs to attract older adults. Pam appeared excited about an upcoming cruise trip: "there's gonna be a pickleball cruise and this friend and I are gonna go on it. So you might want to go on a seven-day cruise to play pickleball." The cited narratives evidence that the pursuit of pickleball has opened doors for social connection for our study participants, and that the pickleball community functions as a reliable support network for its members in later life.

An Intergenerational Pastime

The cross-generational features of pickleball make it unique. The short learning curve of pickleball can explain its intergenerational aspect. People often play with or against different generations during recreational games. It is not unusual to find two or even three generations playing this sport together. Jane spoke of teaching pickleball to her grandchild. She said, "This sport can be played at any age. I introduced the game to my grandson when he was two years old." Pickleball is probably one of the few sports multiple generations can play together at a competitive pace. In fact, a mother-daughter team represents two of the top players in women's doubles in the professional pickleball league as of 2022. In David's terms, "there are not many sports in which a 70-year-old can compete with a 20-year-old." The intergenerational benefits of pickleball appealed to many of our study participants. Other interviewed respondents indicated that playing with younger generations helps them keep in shape and stay mentally active. Tom shared his experiences of competing against younger players:

> I went and played in the State Games of Oklahoma and did very well. I played in 50+ (bracket). But what happened was 19+ (bracket) and 35+ (bracket) and 50+ (bracket) weren't big enough, so they combined all of them. And then I ended up winning it. So that was like really neat.

Events are conducted according to skill levels and age groups in most pickleball competitions. However, it is usual for smaller local pickleball tournaments to combine participants of different age groups when some of the age-based groups do not have enough competitors. In such amalgamated groups, older players must compete against younger rivals. Participants are awarded according to their age groups in such instances, regardless of the combination. This norm is fair across age groups and avoids age-based disadvantages. However, Tom claimed that age was not an issue in his instance of competing against younger players, and he could still win the tournament. Another participant, Carl, was in his 70s but stated that he was unconcerned about playing against younger opponents. With more than 10 years of pickleball experience, Carl usually played at the advanced skill level. Carl expounded on his experience, saying, "I'm playing against 30, 40, 50-year-olds. It helped my mental game not only that but makes me work harder. I don't think of myself as 70 years old, okay that's a number." In a similar vein, he stated that his advanced age did not always pose a disadvantage:

> Smart older players, they play all the time. They will just use their skill and their knowledge to try to beat you. And they can, not 9 out of 10, but they can beat you sometimes. They can beat younger people. Cause they are smart and they are patient, they play with their own ability, they will set you up.

Reestablishing an Identity Through Pickleball

A strong leisure identity affirms one's talents and often becomes a source of recognition (Shamir, 1992). Our study participants disclosed that leisure activities could denote an arena for the development of personal identity. Some participants indicated that they incorporated multiple identities (i.e., work, leisure, etc.). However, the participants identified through pickleball to an exceptional extent. Involvement in pickleball was regarded particularly by retirees as an opportunity to establish a leisure identity after retirement. Being an ambassador appeared to affect their status and made them feel special in the community. Ben illustrated his experiences as an ambassador: "It's almost a prestigious position to a certain extent … it's a privilege to be, but it's also a responsibility that you want to conduct yourself in a manner that you want to bring people to the game." Similarly, Jane said she had earned the position of ambassador because of her achievements in the sport, appearing satisfied with her role in the pickleball community. According to Jane,

> It kind of gave me a little bit of prestige in terms of that ability and having achieved the ranking I have in the tournaments, then I became the go-to person for issues. And I think being an ambassador, you know, I enjoyed that because of the easily resolved conflict. Not that I know so much more, but because of my position, it gives me credibility, which makes you more accepting of what I'm saying.

It was evident that most participants had revised their self-image to an identity that revolved around pickleball. The participants expressed the view that playing pickleball and working as ambassadors formed the focal aspect of their lives. They tended to speak proudly about pickleball, as highlighted by Carl's statement:

> I wear pickleball shirts out, I have a pickleball hanging from the back of my pickup, in my car, the back of my golf cart, so people know that I'm a pickleball player. Any time somebody wants? I'll sit down next to them, I'll explain the game to them.

As their ambassador identity became meaningful, the participants acknowledged their responsibilities as leaders of the pickleball community. Miles was in his early 70s and was once an avid and competitive pickleball player. However, a leg injury stopped him from playing regularly. At the time the interviews were conducted, Miles would sit on a bench outside the pickleball courts, watch others play, and offer his help in arranging players for pickup games. He spoke of his responsibilities as an ambassador:

> I have an email list that's probably got 400 or more pickleball player names on it. I use it when I promote activities and when we do some of those clinics. I built that list. I said, well wait a minute. I'm a pickleball ambassador. You encouraged me to become one. Yeah, that's part of my job. I like to think I contributed something absolutely. There's

> got to you know at least a hundred pickleball players that I got into the game by talking them into it. I'd like to think I did something good for the community and I'm still trying to open new places. Well, I'm doing the best I can, just kind of, on the sidelines.

Ambassadors perform other duties including running clinics, refereeing, and teaching newcomers. They also help to develop pickleball-related infrastructure in their communities. David described his commitments as an ambassador, "I've been all around places that I need to go. I have made commitments to the city parks when it gets built to actually give a whole lot of my time to them to teach kids."

Discussion

The findings of the present study support the belief that engaging in pickleball accords individuals with a promising environment for a healthy life in their later years. The narratives offered by our participants conveyed how pickleball had added durable benefits to their daily lives. We found Stebbins' (2007) serious leisure framework useful for the interpretation of the experiences shared by the participants. Our analysis revealed that pickleball allowed the participants to sustain a physically and mentally active lifestyle. All our participants were active pickleball players and their dedication to this sport resulted in their involvement in the community as ambassadors. Pickleball could sometimes be somewhat physically demanding, but its benefits to participants appeared to outweigh the challenges.

The social characteristics of the pickleball community resulted in friendships that provided genuine collective support. That older pickleball players can socialize actively when they play on the courts could easily be expected. Remarkably, however, the pickleball community offers some contexts in which older adults can make friends and maintain relationships that allow them to either play pickleball together or socialize in their daily lives. This observation aligns with existing literature reporting that leisure can provide significant avenues for the development and maintenance of the behavioral and affective processes of friendship (Adams, 1993). Thus, the current study demonstrates that pickleball can represent an approachable and sustainable opportunity that allows older adults to establish long-lasting friendships. This result is in line with findings from previous research showing socialization was one of the most significant motives for playing pickleball at an advanced age (Casper & Jeon, 2018).

The hospitable atmosphere of pickleball communities notwithstanding the skill levels of members denotes a unique aspect. The findings revealed that newcomers are always welcomed and that pickleball community members always attempt to seamlessly involve new individuals within their groups. This finding supports the conclusion drawn by a previous study that pickleball players created a distinctive social world representing convivial surroundings (Heo et al., 2018). Our findings are also congruent with previously offered suggestions that the personality trait of being

open to experience is observed among older pickleball players and contributes to their long-term well-being and fulfillment (Ryu et al., 2022).

The interviews also disclosed that pickleball triggered vibrant intergenerational interactions. According to the study participants, older adults must sometimes compete against younger players. Also, multiple generations can spend leisure time together by introducing the sport to each other and practicing it together. As an intergenerational sports activity, pickleball can enhance connections between younger and older generations and deliver some constructive family leisure time. This finding supports previous research demonstrating that having interactions of college students with older adults while hosting pickleball competitions significantly lowered agism. The popularity of pickleball will probably increase because it is almost the only sports activity in which multiple generations can participate simultaneously because of unique characteristics such as easy access and a short learning curve.

Playing pickleball became the focal life interest of the participants, and it was evident during the interviews that pickleball provided meaning and substance to older adults. All the participants demonstrated their dedication to pickleball, which caused them to become pickleball ambassadors in their communities. Individuals are not merely granted ambassador positions; rather, the positions are earned through their demonstrated commitment to the sport. All ambassadors must undergo an application process. The USAPA provides name cards to ambassadors, who use them in varying settings. Some participants proudly presented their name cards to the researchers during their interviews. The ambassador role appeared to construct leisure-based identities in the participants. Such identities were evidently reinforced in the retirees who formed our sample. Their narratives bolstered the significance of establishing leisure identities in later life (Heo et al., 2013), and the context-specific explorations of older pickleball players strengthened our findings.

Limitations of the Study

We acknowledge some limitations of our study. The relatively small sample size renders it difficult to draw generalized conclusions about the behaviors of older adults in the pickleball community. The homogeneity of the sample denotes an additional limiting factor (i.e., high education level and a high percentage of Caucasians). This study was conducted exclusively with pickleball players in the United States. The International Federation of Pickleball (2022) reports that pickleball is played in more than 60 countries. The federation also appoints ambassadors with roles similar to that discharged by the participants in our study. Ambassadors are expected to form the core drivers of the growth of pickleball as the sport continues to grow in North America and elsewhere. Compiling the perspectives of ambassadors across the world could reinforce the results of our study. The ambassadors we recruited belonged to a southern state in the United States, which appoints a fairly large number of ambassadors because it has registered one of the largest and most rapid rises in the number of pickleball players and the number of pickleball tournaments. The USAPA (2022) has

appointed more than 100 ambassadors in the state where this study was conducted. The number of ambassadors varies significantly from state to state, with some appointing less than 10 ambassadors. Ambassadors from smaller states would probably confront different challenges and responsibilities. For example, the duties of ambassadors would be more diversified in regions registering the vibrant growth of pickleball and would entail aspects such as organizing tournaments, training referees, and running workshops. However, ambassadors appointed in states where pickleball is not very popular would focus more on advertising and recruiting participants for local clubs.

Despite the limitations, the present study contributes to the extant literature highlighting the value of engaging in sports activities in later life. Our findings offer supplemental insights into the positive functions of sports activities for older adults. The pickleball phenomenon is advancing briskly in the United States and in other nations. However, the research community has not yet delved sufficiently into the pickleball phenomenon despite the sport's fast growth. The number of pickleball players is expected to continue to rise rapidly. Further studies are warranted to explore the physical and mental health benefits of playing pickleball.

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